

The FLACC Pain Scale

Sometimes it is difficult to assess pain in children who are non-verbal. The FLACC Pain Scale is a system that can help parents and professionals assess pain levels in children who have limited or no expressive communication. The diagram shows the categories for scoring. Zero, one or two points are given to each of the five categories: Face, Legs, Activity, Cry and Consolability.

Interpreting the Behaviour Score

Each category is scored on the 0-2 scale, which results in a total score of 0-10

- 0

relaxed and comfortable
- 1-3
- mild discomfort

4-6

moderate pain

7-10

Categories ▼	Score: Zero ▼	Score: One ▼	Score Two ▼
Face F	No particular expression or smile	Occasional grimace or frown, withdrawn, disinterested.	Frequent to constant quivering chin, clenched jaw.
Legs L	Normal position or relaxed	Uneasy, restless, tense.	Kicking, or legs drawn up.
Activity A	Lying quietly, normal position moves easily.	Squirming, shifting back and forth, tense.	Arched, rigid or jerking.
Cry C	No crying (awake or asleep)	Moans or whimpers; occasional complaint	Crying steadily, screams or sobs, frequent complaints.
Consolability C	Content, relaxed.	Reassured by occasional touching hugging or being talked to, distractable.	Difficulty to console or comfort

If a child is showing these behaviours, it doesn't necessarily mean that they are in pain, as some of the behaviours measured by the FLACC scale can happen for other reasons. However, parents are advised to follow up high scores with a professional.

